

Natural History





About the Course

Students learn to observe a variety of creatures through their Nature Reader, including insects, birds, plants, and spiders. Coordinating afternoon activities are provided in Outdoor Work.

This topic is included in the following course(s): Science: Grade 1

About Science: Grade 1

In Level 1, learners are developing familiarity and friendship with Creation through the most accessible Things, simple text, and basic concepts.

Science: Grade 1

The Big Picture:

To accomplish the goal of supporting a relationship with the Things of the Universe, a Mason science program consists of nature lore, natural history, and general science. Nature immersion, inquiry, community connection, and supportive literature are woven into each of these three parts. Form 1 learners in Grades 1-3 are at the beginning of this relationship: developing familiarity and friendship with Creation. Their sense of community is primarily focused on their immediate environment at this stage, but they are curious about others. The familiarity with foundational knowledge grown and nurtured in Form 1 prepares them for greater curiosity and personal interest in Form 2.

Nature lore is timeless knowledge that is passed through a community, much like a grandmother passes on how to make that special bread when the dough just 'feels right.' Like Mason, we strive to pass on this knowledge primarily through outdoor work. Group nature walks, seasonal readings, and topics in scouting are provided as an Outdoor Work resource in the Quick Links. If desired, literature suggestions to support lore can be found in the Community Read Alouds resource (in Literature Grades 1-3).



Placement & Combining Tips

About Science: Grade 1

In Level 1, learners are developing familiarity and friendship with Creation through the most accessible Things, simple text, and basic concepts.



Scheduling

GRADE	SCHEDULE INFO.	BOOKS
1	Natural History: Grade 1 1 time/week 10 min	Walks with a Naturalist: Living Nature Reader Volume 1

Sample Weekly View

Day 1	Day 2	Day 3	Day 4	Day 5
Science: Grade 1				
Natural History: Grade 1 Nature Walks & Scouting: Grades 1-8	Nature Notebook: Grade 1		General Science: Grade 1	



Planning & Prep

Permission to print for non-commercial use. See Alveary group use policy to use lessons in a group context.

LINKS: Click text or scan the QR code in the top corner of the lesson plan pages to view online resources associated with the lessons.

Responsibility for previewing all links rests with the teacher. All links were checked at the time of publication; however, websites change frequently and may contain objectionable content. Please report broken links by contacting us through our website.

Science: Grade 1

- ☐ Obtain any supplies indicated on the science or grade-level supply lists.
- ☐ Download any apps and shortcut any desired links.

Nature Lore:

- ☐ Bookmark your Outdoor Work Quick Link, so that you have it available on your weekly outing. Outdoor Work is generally flexible for your location and season and can be moved around in the schedule to incorporate or substitute Natural History Club outings.
- ☐ Print or bookmark grade-specific nature notebook suggestions to support natural history and general science. Notebooking can be done on a walk, during occupations, or as a field trip, as appropriate.

Special Topics & Field Trips

Science: Grade 1

- ☐ Learn a few of your local species on these special topics using the internet, field guides, or your local nature preserve, conservancy, or state/national park.
- ☐ Note whether there are particular locations nearby for the student to easily notice the special topics on walks or during afternoon occupations.

Natural History: Grade 1

- Term 1: insects, spiders, and birds
- Term 2: wild seeds and birds
- Term 3: insects, spiders, and tree buds

Term Prep & Teacher Tips

Science: Grade 1

Object lesson prompts are woven into the lessons as appropriate, but teachers are encouraged to read corresponding Handbook of Nature Study (HoNS) selections each term:

Natural History: Grade 1

- ☐ Term 1: ants p.369-374, bees p.384-395
- ☐ Term 2: squirrels p.233-237, 1-2 species of birds from p.50-141
- ☐ Term 3: lightning bugs p.367-368, spiders p.435-446



Books & Resources

For book rationales and purchase options, click the Book List link or scan the QR code below.

∞ [View Book List Details](#)

Natural History: Grade 1



Walks with a Naturalist: Living Nature Reader Volume 1



Supplies

For supply list details and basic supplies helpful to have on hand, click the links or scan the QR code below.

∞ [View Basic Supplies](#)

(No Subject Supplies Assigned)



Quick Links

Related Course Quick Links

- ∞ [Extra Helpings](#)
- ∞ [Foundations \(See Section 13: Science\)](#)
- ∞ [Outdoor Work](#)
- ∞ [Seek app from iNaturalist](#)
- ∞ [SkyView Lite for Android](#)
- ∞ [SkyView Lite for iOS](#)

Click THIS text
or scan the QR
code for links.



Natural History: Grade 1

How To Teach



Introduce

- Begin each lesson with learners' existing knowledge. If the book or activity is new or unfamiliar, then look at the title, a picture, or guidance in the lesson plan to help discuss what students think, drawing on previous experience. If continuing or revisiting a topic or activity, then recap. The lesson plans often help with this.
- Some learners may benefit from using pictures or looking back briefly.
- Allow them time to share any concerns and come alongside, as needed.



Complete

- Read, or do, as instructed in the lessons, noting any Teacher Tips provided. Learners should always have their nature journal or some other notebook/paper available in case they need to draw or diagram during the lesson.
- When reading to pre-readers, point to the words as you read, even if it seems like they aren't paying attention.
- If learners do not understand a word or concept, do not worry. Try to show them with a picture or connect the idea to something they have seen in real life. They are learning much by the way and will likely build understanding over the term, the year, or beyond.



Narrate

- Process the ideas of the lesson by retelling the events in sequence, describing a scene or setting, explaining a concept, etc.
- Learners may use words, pictures, Legos, dolls, etc., to process and convey ideas in the manner most natural to them.
- Teachers may take turns to model.



Discuss

- Consider together any thoughts, confusion, or concerns about the passage.
- Questions/topics for further discussion are often provided in the lesson plans to help. There are no right or wrong answers to these. If teachers want to keep ideas active in the mind, these can also be used at other times to keep the ideas in the working memory.



Connect

- Follow any extra links, examine any sidebars in the text, look at pictures, etc., depending on learner interest.
- These can also be viewed as alternative ways to engage.

Natural History: Grade 1

[Click THIS text or scan the QR code for links.](#)



Term 1

WEEK 1 10m Natural History: Grade 1 - Lesson 1

A Sense of Fall

Materials: Walks with a Naturalist 1

PREP: Read Teacher Tip

→ INTRO

Have you ever gone on a walk with a naturalist or park ranger? If so, what was that like? These are people who spend a LOT of time getting to know nature. This book has been written especially for YOU by a naturalist! Today, she is going to introduce herself and help us start to think about the upcoming season. She'll take us on her walks all year long!

→ READ, NARRATE, & DISCUSS

p.xvii-3 "Hello, readers!" - "go outside!"

Read the definitions and notes at the end of each reading, as desired.

- When you think about the fall season, what do you think of? What do you look forward to? Have you noticed any of these signs of fall yet?

→ SUPPLEMENTAL

∞ Video Link: Fall Colors in Texas (2:08)

∞ Video Link: Wood Thrush Song (1:35)

∞ Video Link: Senses Nature Walk (6:34)

★ TEACHER TIP

Supplemental links for optional support are provided at the END of the lesson. They can be used at any point to help generate interest during the introduction, to enliven the lesson itself, or to add to discussion later. They are NOT required and should NOT take away from the narration and discussion. Experiment and see what works best for your student(s).

• OUTDOOR WORK

Weekly walks and daily outdoor time are vital! Resources in Quick Links.

WEEK 2 10m Natural History: Grade 1 - Lesson 2

Shake a Bush

Materials: Walks with a Naturalist 1

PREP: Read Teacher Tip

→ INTRO

Look at the picture on p.4. Have you ever seen a creature like this before? What kinds of 'bugs' have you noticed? Briefly share in word or picture.

→ READ, NARRATE, & DISCUSS

p.4-6 "One of my" - "can you find?"

- What do you think makes a leafhopper a leafhopper? What does it do? How is it made?

→ SUPPLEMENTAL

∞ Video Link: Jumping Hoppers in Slow Motion (1:44-3:23)

★ TEACHER TIP

It can sometimes be unnerving for students not to get an immediate answer to a question. Encourage them to sit with big questions, like the one in today's suggested discussion, while they continue to make observations.

• OUTDOOR WORK

Weekly walks and daily outdoor time are vital! Resources in Quick Links.

WEEK 3 10m Natural History: Grade 1 - Lesson 3

Ants in My Plants

Materials: Walks with a Naturalist 1

PREP: Read Teacher Tip

→ INTRO

Draw a picture or diagram of an ant or other insect (or a partner might diagram alongside a verbal drawing). What parts do you recall?

→ READ, NARRATE, & DISCUSS

p.8-11 "In 'Shake'" - "and differences!"

- Compare the ant on p.9 to the leafhopper on p.5. How are they similar? How are they different?

★ TEACHER TIP

If students need support drawing or diagramming, the teacher may do any activities with them in tandem or act as their scribe.

• OUTDOOR WORK

Weekly walks and daily outdoor time are vital! Resources in Quick Links.

Natural History: Grade 1

[Click THIS text or scan the QR code for links.](#)



Term 1

- Add to the drawing you did before the reading or draw a new one. Can you remember the parts of an insect? (3 body segments, 6 legs)
- Have you noticed insects outside? What were they doing? Where were they? What made that place a good home?

→ SUPPLEMENTAL

- ∞ Video Link: All the Life Stages of an Ant (1:34)
- ∞ Video Link: Flying Ants Up Close (5:22)